

ASSIGNMENT #02 / REVISED GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

ASCENDANT IMPACT

A cinematic one-versus-one cyber-fantasy martial-arts action fighter

AUTHOR	VERSION	ENGINE / PLATFORM
Anthony T.	0.4 - 2026-07-24	Unreal Engine 5.8 / PC

REVISION MARKERS **REVISED** = feedback-driven clarification **NEW** = added implementation rule or milestone

01

Executive Summary

Choose an Ascendant operative. Survive one complete duel. Earn the spectacle.

REVISED — HIGH CONCEPT The player selects Agent Echo or Agent Nova and enters the Shattered Ring to fight Crimson Vanguard / Project Valor-7 in one complete third-person duel. Combat is primarily real time: movement, attacks, dodges, perfect dodges, and counters build Ascension energy and earn brief anime-inspired cinematic bursts, culminating in one recoverable Final Clash.

Scope lock. The course prototype remains one player, one authored AI opponent, one official arena, one shared player-combat framework, four authored rival attacks, and one complete duel with win and loss outcomes.

GENRE	PLAYER MODE	TARGET SESSION	ENGINE / PLATFORM
Third-person action fighter	1 player vs. authored AI; Echo or Nova selectable	3–5 minutes	Unreal Engine 5.8 / PC

Design pillars

#	PILLAR	PLAYER-FACING MEANING
1	Skill Creates Spectacle	Readable timing and deliberate decisions earn the strongest visual rewards.
2	Cinematic Rhythm	Brief camera, hit-stop, impact-frame, and VFX bursts punctuate combat without replacing it.

#	PILLAR	PLAYER-FACING MEANING
3	Operative Identity vs. Vanguard Force	Echo emphasizes precision and controlled timing; Nova emphasizes speed and aggressive momentum; Crimson Vanguard embodies armor, pressure, and overwhelming force.

REVISED — CHARACTER MOTIVATION Echo and Nova are Ascendant operatives entering the Shattered Ring to survive a live combat evaluation against Project Valor-7, an armored Vanguard unit designed to push enhanced fighters beyond their operational limits.

02

Real-Time Combat & Selectable Player Roster

The duel is an action-combat game with short earned timing prompts, not a sequence of QTE scenes.

PRESERVED — CONTROL MODEL Movement, lock-on, light attacks, dodge, perfect dodge, counter, health, spacing, and opponent reads occur in real time. Impact Windows and the Final Clash are brief authored overlays triggered by gameplay performance. They never replace the main combat loop, never auto-play an entire fight, and always return control to the player.

Core loop

1. READ	2. RESPOND	3. BUILD	4. IMPACT	5. ESCALATE	6. CLASH
Read Crimson Vanguard's telegraph.	Attack, dodge, or counter.	Earn Ascension energy.	Choose the timing input.	Adapt to Phase 2.	Attempt the Final Clash.

Selectable roster

FIGHTER	COMBAT IDENTITY	PROTOTYPE EXPRESSION
Agent Echo — 6'0" / 183 cm	Lean precision striker	Controlled spacing, deliberate movement, perfect-dodge timing, counters, restrained orange accents.
Agent Nova — 5'8" / 173 cm	Agile pressure striker	Faster visual rhythm, lateral movement, aggressive momentum, preserved costume palette, cyan-white combat energy.

NEW — SHARED PLAYER-KIT SCOPE RULE Echo and Nova are selected before the duel and share the same prototype framework: movement, lock-on, light attack sequence, dodge, perfect dodge, counter, health, Ascension Meter, Impact Windows, and Final Clash. Their initial differences are animation presentation, stance and movement personality, VFX language, timing flavor, and character introduction. Fully unique move sets, separate balance systems, and extensive character-specific cinematics are deferred until the base duel is stable. One signature cinematic variation may be considered only after that foundation is approved.

Impact Windows

A qualifying real-time event—such as a perfect dodge, counter, or approved combo milestone—can open one short contextual timing prompt. Success extends the exchange into a 1–3 second choreographed burst. Failure does not auto-correct the input; the game returns immediately to normal combat.

WINDOW	TRIGGER	PROVISIONAL RESPONSE TIME	FAILURE RESULT
First Impact Window	First successful perfect dodge or counter	0.75 seconds	No cinematic extension; return to combat with no extra punishment
Standard Impact Window	Approved skill event after cooldown	0.35–0.50 seconds	No extension; return to combat

PRESERVED — ONBOARDING RULE The first Impact Window is intentionally wider, but it still requires the player’s input and must be earned through a successful real-time defensive action. The game does not press the input for the player and does not convert a miss into success.

03

Ascension Meter, Final Clash & Encounter Flow

The established meter, unlock, and failed-Clash recovery rules remain intact.

Ascension Meter

PRESERVED — METER DEFINITION Ascension Meter is a visible 0–100 resource earned only through active combat decisions. It does not fill from waiting or elapsed time. Provisional gains remain subject to playtest tuning.

PLAYER EVENT	METER GAIN	DESIGN INTENT
Light-combo finisher	+5	Small reward for sustained offense
Perfect dodge	+12	Reward a clean defensive read
Successful counter	+15	Reward converting the opening

PLAYER EVENT	METER GAIN	DESIGN INTENT
Impact Window success	+20	Reward execution during an earned cinematic beat
Taking damage / waiting	+0	Prevent passive progress

Final Clash unlock rule

REVISED — SINGLE GATE The Final Clash becomes available only when BOTH conditions are true: Ascension Meter is full at 100 AND Crimson Vanguard's health is at or below 25%. If one condition is met first, the Clash remains locked until the other is met. Once eligible, the player chooses to initiate the Clash with a contextual input during neutral or after a successful counter.

Final Clash resolution

OUTCOME	RULE	RETURN STATE
Success	Complete both timing beats; the finishing sequence defeats Crimson Vanguard and ends the duel.	Win screen
Failure	Separate both fighters; preserve current health with Crimson Vanguard held at a 1 HP floor; reduce meter to 50; apply a 3-second re-trigger cooldown.	Return to Neutral; rebuild meter and try again

PRESERVED — FAILED CLASH RECOVERY A failed Final Clash does not restart the duel, kill the player automatically, or leave either fighter in a cinematic state. It creates a meaningful meter setback, restores valid combat states, and preserves a recoverable path to victory.

Encounter flow

BEAT	PROVISIONAL RULE	PLAYER EXPERIENCE
Opening	Selection, abbreviated entrance, then immediate control	Establish identity and stakes without delaying play
Phase 1	Readable armored pressure; onboarding Impact Window available	Learn Crimson Vanguard's rhythm
Phase 2	Begins at 50% Crimson Vanguard health; same attacks, stronger pressure	Apply learned reads under stress
Climax	Meter 100 + Crimson Vanguard health $\leq 25\%$	Player chooses the Final Clash attempt
Win / Loss	Final Clash success / selected fighter health reaches zero	Complete duel loop

04

Crimson Vanguard — Authored Rival AI

A compact state machine or Behavior Tree controls readable, testable armored pressure.

REVISED — RUNTIME AI BOUNDARY Crimson Vanguard is controlled by authored Unreal gameplay AI. The packaged duel makes no runtime LLM calls, does not learn from the player, and does not generate attacks or choreography dynamically.

State flow and provisional timing

Idle / Reposition → Select Attack → Telegraph → Active Attack → Recover → Return to Neutral

STATE	PURPOSE	PHASE 1	PHASE 2	EXIT CONDITION
Idle / Reposition	Face the selected fighter and maintain armored pressure	0.60–1.20 s	0.35–0.80 s	Valid range and line
Select Attack	Choose one of four authored attacks by range and cooldown	0.10–0.20 s	0.10–0.20 s	Attack selected
Telegraph	Show committed pose, warning lights, sound, and readable direction	0.55–0.95 s	0.40–0.75 s	Telegraph completes
Active Attack	Apply authored movement, gauntlet force, hitbox, reach, or short propulsion	0.18–0.45 s	0.18–0.45 s	Active frames end
Recover	Expose a deliberate punish opening after the committed strike	0.45–0.90 s	0.35–0.75 s	Recovery completes
Return to Neutral	Clear attack flags and restore valid locomotion	0.10–0.20 s	0.10–0.20 s	Neutral restored

Behavioral intent. Crimson Vanguard advances as a large armored threat: attacks are committed rather than random, propulsion closes short gaps explosively, gauntlets communicate force, and every major offense exposes a clear recovery opening. Armor and scale may intensify presentation, but they do not remove readable counterplay.

Four-attack course set

AUTHORED ATTACK	RANGE / PURPOSE	READABILITY REQUIREMENT
Authored attack A	Close-range committed gauntlet force	Distinct wind-up and punishable recovery
Authored attack B	Committed forward-pressure sequence	Visible first beat and stable tracking limit
Authored attack C	Armored reach and space control	Clear body direction and visible active range
Authored attack D	Short propulsion-assisted approach	Thruster cue before movement; no hidden full-arena snap

Phase 2 escalation

REVISED — PHASE 2 Phase 2 begins when Crimson Vanguard reaches 50% health. The phase change is committed on Return to Neutral, then signaled once with stronger thruster output, warning lights, sound, and armor-energy presentation. It uses the same four authored attacks—no transformation rig and no second move set.

PARAMETER	PHASE 1	PHASE 2
Reposition delay	0.60–1.20 s	0.35–0.80 s
Forward pressure	Measured advances	More frequent advances and shorter hesitation
Attack weighting	Balanced authored selection	More aggressive close-range and gap-closing weight
Presentation	Readable red-orange systems	Stronger thruster, warning-light, sound, and armor-energy cues
Attack set	Four authored attacks	Same four authored attacks

05

Gray-Box Vertical Slice & Technical Milestones

Validate the complete gameplay contract before expanding presentation.

PRESERVED — GRAY-BOX MILESTONE The first vertical slice uses proxy Echo or Nova, proxy Crimson Vanguard, the official arena footprint, one authored rival attack, one player defensive response, one Impact Window, meter gain, and a clean return to neutral. It proves the real-time-to-cinematic handoff before final characters, VFX, or expanded choreography.

MILESTONE	REQUIRED PROOF	GATE
M1 — Combat gray box	Movement, lock-on, light sequence, dodge, perfect dodge, counter, health	Playable loop with selected proxy
M2 — Rival state loop	All six AI states and one Crimson Vanguard attack complete without deadlock	Returns to Neutral every attempt
M3 — Impact handoff	Earned prompt, success/failure branches, restored control	No forced success or stranded cinematic state
M4 — Complete duel	Meter, Phase 2, Final Clash, failure recovery, win/loss	Start-to-finish course prototype
M5 — Presentation pass	Approved character treatment, arena reaction, camera, VFX, sound	Only after M4 is stable

Implementation safeguards

- Use authored state-machine or Behavior Tree logic with visible debug state names and deterministic recovery paths.
- Separate gameplay timing from cinematic presentation so hit-stop, camera, and VFX can be disabled during diagnosis.
- Restore input, collision, locomotion, lock-on, and AI state explicitly after every Impact Window and Final Clash branch.
- Validate both selectable avatars against the same collision, targeting, reach, and arena-boundary tests.
- Treat all timing ranges, meter values, and health thresholds as provisional until validated through playtesting and finalized by the designer.

06

AI-Assisted Development Architecture

Tools may accelerate production, but runtime behavior and creative acceptance remain authored and human-approved.

PRESERVED — HUMAN APPROVAL GATE Generative tools may support ideation, reference exploration, documentation, and offline draft assets. No generated combat behavior, character asset, animation, VFX, sound, or text enters the course build without human review, technical validation, rights review, and explicit approval.

AREA	ALLOWED SUPPORT	COURSE-BUILD BOUNDARY
Design	Brainstorming, comparison, tuning hypotheses, documentation drafts	Designer approves all rules and numbers
Visual development	Reference exploration and look-direction drafts	Human-selected assets only; no automatic final import
Code support	Offline implementation suggestions and debugging assistance	Reviewed source and authored Unreal runtime logic
Runtime opponent	None	Crimson Vanguard uses deterministic authored AI; no runtime LLM
Playable fighters	None at runtime	Player input controls Echo or Nova; no agent automation

07

Character Readability, Scale & Opening Flow

Three distinct combat identities remain legible inside one shared design family.

Character readability comparison

CATEGORY	AGENT ECHO	AGENT NOVA	CRIMSON VANGUARD
Combat identity	Precision and controlled timing	Speed and aggressive momentum	Armor, pressure, overwhelming force
Movement	Deliberate spacing and counters	Fast lateral rhythm and forward intent	Committed advances and short propulsion
Silhouette	Lean, upright technical striker	Compact, agile layered profile	Substantially broader armored mass
Material family	Matte black and charcoal technical suit	Black, charcoal, orange, light-gray helmet cap	Red armor over black structure
Energy / VFX	Controlled orange accents	Cyan-white combat energy or selected telegraphs	Red-orange systems and warning lights
Gameplay role	Selectable player avatar	Selectable player avatar	Sole authored AI rival / boss
Readability target	Exact timing and clear counter intent	Momentum without visual noise	Threatening reach with obvious tells and recovery

REVISED — COLOR DIRECTION Echo keeps restrained orange accents. Nova’s existing black, charcoal, orange, and light-gray costume design is preserved; cyan-white is reserved for combat energy, telegraphs, or selected VFX accents when separation is needed. Crimson Vanguard reads through red armor, black structure, and red-orange systems and warning lights.

Character scale

Agent Nova stands 5'8", Agent Echo stands 6'0", and Crimson Vanguard stands 6'10". The rival is deliberately taller and substantially broader than either playable fighter, creating immediate threat and visual contrast while remaining within a scale that supports readable close-range martial-arts combat. The height difference must not create unfair hidden reach or collision behavior.

Character selection and opening flow

- Echo and Nova appear in a clean editorial character-selection interface.
- The player briefly moves between both options.
- Echo is selected in the current concept-video version.
- Technical and equipment panels animate around the selected fighter.
- The interface transitions into the established arena.
- The camera moves behind the selected fighter.
- Crimson Vanguard enters through the far doorway.
- The duel begins.

CONCEPT DIRECTION — OPENING PRESENTATION The complete selection-to-arena transition describes the intended concept presentation. The course build may use a simplified selection screen and abbreviated arena entrance while preserving the same readable sequence.

CONCEPT VIDEO Updated Concept Visualization — Link to be added.

08

Visual Assets & Official Version 1 Arena

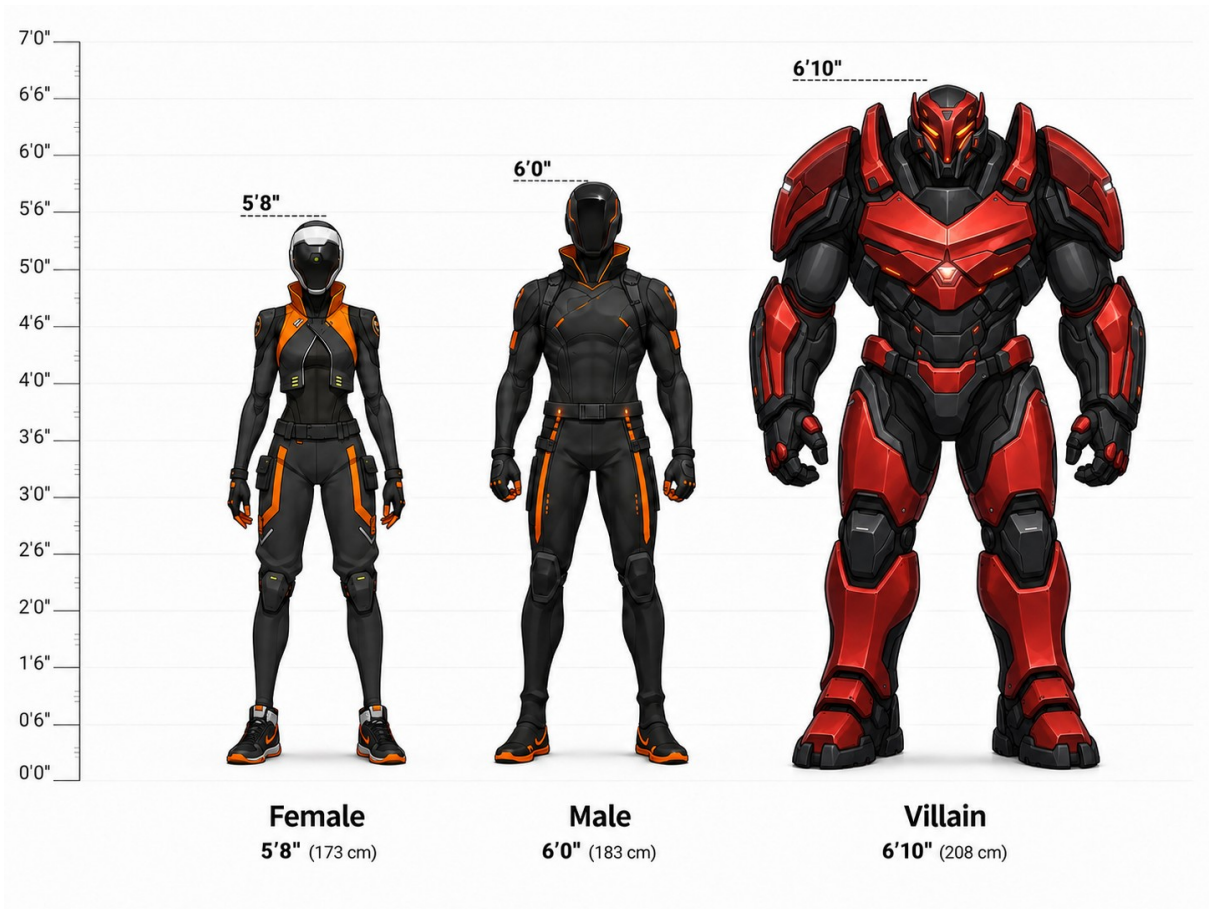
Approved reference direction for the two selectable fighters, the boss rival, scale, and duel space.

Official arena direction

The established industrial Shattered Ring arena is locked as the official Version 1 environment. Alternate environment explorations do not replace it in the course prototype.

ARENA REQUIREMENT	VERSION 1 FUNCTION
Central combat floor	Open, readable space for spacing, lock-on, dodges, counters, and Final Clash staging
Far doorway	Dedicated Crimson Vanguard entrance axis
Reverse third-person framing	Clear camera position behind the selected fighter
Side-on readability	Readable silhouettes and attack direction during lateral exchanges
Environmental reaction	Visible but controlled reaction during major impacts without adding gameplay hazards

Character Scale Reference



Established Arena Reference

Industrial Arena Environment Reference Sheet

1. Main Arena Identity / Establishing Reference



2. Reverse Angle / Hero-Side Framing



3. Side-Combat Gameplay Angle



-  • Futuristic industrial combat arena
-  • Raw concrete architecture with black steel framing
-  • Orange accent rails, paint drips, and trim
-  • Strong overhead skylight shadows across the floor
-  • Cold atmospheric haze and moody cinematic lighting
-  • Open central floor designed for combat staging

Agent Echo — Playable Precision Fighter



Agent Nova — Playable Pressure Fighter



Crimson Vanguard / Project Valor-7 — Authored Boss Rival

HEAD / OPTICS



CRIMSON VANGUARD | PROJECT VALOR-7



BACK / THRUSTERS



CHEST / POWER CORE



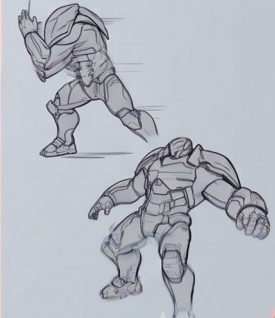
ORTHOGRAPHIC VIEWS



LEFT ARM / GAUNTLET



ACTION VIGNETTES



SYSTEM STATS

POWER		9/10
ARMOR		9/10
MOBILITY		6/10
SYSTEMS		7/10

REF: Screenshots 2026-07-23 [All timestamp]



UNITS DESCRIPTION:

A high-end, heavily armored tactical mech unit, optimized for front-line vanguard operations. Distinctive for its Crimson Valor color scheme and integrated high yield thermal-energy core. Known for unmatched durability and powerful, integrated plasma-gauntlet weapons.

Course Scope Lock & Future Expansion

Version 0.4 protects one complete duel as the course prototype.

SCOPE LOCK The required prototype is complete when the player can select Echo or Nova, enter the official arena, fight Crimson Vanguard through both phases, earn and resolve Impact Windows, reach and retry the Final Clash, and finish with a valid win or loss. Recommendations beyond that loop are flagged as future scope.

Included in the course prototype

- One player versus one authored AI opponent.
- Two selectable player avatars using one shared core combat framework.
- One Crimson Vanguard boss with six states, four attacks, and a parameter-based Phase 2.
- One official industrial arena, one complete duel, and complete win/loss handling.
- Impact Window onboarding, Ascension Meter, Final Clash unlock, and failed-Clash recovery.
- Human approval gates and no runtime LLM-controlled fighters.

Deferred future scope

- Local or online PvP.
- Unique Echo and Nova move sets, separate balance systems, or extensive character cinematics.
- A playable Crimson Vanguard combat kit.
- Multi-enemy encounters, campaign progression, additional arenas, or extended enemy gauntlets.
- Transformations, second boss kits, additional characters, modes, weapons, or story chapters.

FUTURE SCOPE — NOT PART OF THE COURSE PROTOTYPE Future PvP may allow Echo and Nova to fight each other or make Crimson Vanguard available as a heavyweight playable archetype, but this is outside the course prototype.

Definition of done

AREA	ACCEPTANCE CONDITION
Combat	Real-time controls remain responsive before and after every cinematic beat
Selection	Either avatar enters the same complete shared-framework duel
AI	Crimson Vanguard completes all six states and never strands the encounter
Phase 2	50% health escalation changes pressure parameters and presentation, not the attack set
Climax	Final Clash obeys both unlock conditions and supports recovery after failure
Readability	Echo, Nova, and Crimson Vanguard remain legible in motion and at combat distance
Scope	One complete duel runs start to finish in Unreal Engine 5.8 on PC

Version 0.4 Revision Log & Open Design Decisions

Visible record of the character-structure update and the remaining decisions.

Revision log

SECTION	VERSION 0.4 CHANGE	STATUS
Executive Summary / Player Mode	Nova changed from authored rival to selectable player; selection of Echo or Nova added	Revised
Design Pillars / Motivation	Three-way operative-and-boss contrast replaces Echo-versus-Nova conflict	Revised
Core Loop / Meter / Final Clash	All rival and health references now target Crimson Vanguard; established rules retained	Revised
Rival AI / Phase 2	Crimson Vanguard became sole authored AI rival; six states, four attacks, and parameter escalation preserved	Revised
Player Roster	Shared player-kit scope rule added; unique kits and extensive cinematics deferred	New
Character Readability	Echo, Nova, and Crimson Vanguard comparison and cyan-white Nova combat-energy rule added	Revised
Character Scale	Supplied height reference and fair-reach/collision requirement added	New
Selection / Opening	Editorial selection and arena-entry concept flow added with simplified course-build allowance	New
Visual Assets / Arena	Five supplied reference sheets inserted; established industrial arena locked as Version 1	New
Future Scope	PvP, multi-enemy encounters, campaigns, additional arenas, and gauntlets remain deferred	Reaffirmed
Engine / Concept Video	Engine corrected to Unreal Engine 5.8 / PC; honest concept-video placeholder added	Revised

Provisional Design Decisions for Playtesting

DECISION	PROVISIONAL VERSION 0.4 POSITION
Exact combat timing and meter tuning	Keep all published timing ranges, gains, and thresholds provisional until playtest review.
Echo / Nova timing flavor	Use the same mechanics and balance framework; approve only presentation-level timing flavor at first.
Nova cyan-white application	Apply to combat energy, telegraphs, or selected VFX—not a costume recolor—unless later readability testing supports a broader application.
Signature cinematic variation	Defer; consider one per fighter only after the shared base duel is stable.
Selection and entrance fidelity	Use a simplified selection screen and abbreviated arena entrance for the course build.
Crimson Vanguard display name	Use “Crimson Vanguard / Project Valor-7” formally; finalize the shorter in-combat UI label.
Scale, reach, and collision validation	Validate gameplay collision and hit reach only after both avatars pass the same close-range tests.
Updated concept visualization	Link remains pending; the document stands alone without it.

CENTRAL PROMISE Real-time martial-arts combat rewards player skill with brief, earned anime-style cinematic spectacle.